

2024 to play for the country. India, on the other hand, recalled its talismanic forward Sunil Chhetri **(right)** from international retirement.

Every contest seeks an equilibrium, which has happened with the arrival of Hamza, who has been likened to Argentine superstar Lionel Messi by Bangladesh national team captain Jamal Bhuyan.

"Hamza is a Premier League player. He is our Messi. Everyone in our team welcomes and respects him," Jamal was quoted as saying in a recent interaction with the media.

This was the first time the senior men's national football team will play a competitive match in the refurbished Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, which has been refitted with a natural turf that meets international standards.

A large contingent of Bangladeshi media has made its way to the scenic venue through the international border in Sylhet (which it shares with Meghalaya), eager to witness the contest between Chhetri and Hamza.

Indian head coach Manolo Marquez, said, "I think he (Hamza) is a very good player. He was playing in the Premier League, now he is playing in the (EFL) Championship (with Sheffield United), and that team is likely to be promoted. I think it is not only good for Bangladesh but also for Asian football that players like him can play in the national team."

Sandesh Jhingan, the mainstay of India's defence, felt that Chhetri remains a threat for any team. "He has scored 95 goals, so you always expect him to score. We are just happy to have him back. He is a threat to every team because of the quality he has."

Sandesh kept the Indian striker ahead in the Sunil vs Hamza contest.

Amitabha Das Shama



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